

SkillBoost AI

Customer & MVP Blueprint

AI-Powered Career Guidance · India Market · June 2025

82

Customer Clarity

88

Problem Severity

76

PMF Potential

71

MVP Readiness

■ FINAL VERDICT: STRONG DEMAND SIGNAL — CONDITIONAL GO · Overall Score: 74/100

01 Executive Summary

Startup	SkillBoost AI — AI-powered career guidance platform
Problem	Tier 2/3 engineering students lack personalised, affordable career coaching
Target Market	~5M Tier 2/3 B.Tech / BCA / BSc CS students, India
SAM	\$4.2B — India online career guidance & skill-dev market
Model	Freemium → Subscription (Rs 99–499/month) + Premium upsell
Stage	Early prototype · Positive qualitative feedback · Pre-revenue
Founder Fit	8.1/10 — Lived the problem; full-stack technical skills
Verdict	Conditional GO — validate retention & paying cohort in 30 days

- India produces 1.5M+ engineering grads/year; <20% land degree-relevant jobs — the pain is real and large.
- No competitor combines AI personalisation + career path mapping + India-native pricing in one product.
- Gen-AI cost curves and smartphone penetration create a rare timing window for a seed-stage founder.
- Primary risks: solo-founder execution bandwidth, price sensitivity, and unproven D30 retention.

02 Ideal Customer Profile (ICP)

Attribute	Description
Institution	Tier 2 / Tier 3 engineering or polytechnic colleges in India
Degree & Year	B.Tech / BCA / BSc CS — 2nd, 3rd, or 4th year students
Geography	Semi-urban India: UP, Bihar, MP, Rajasthan, Maharashtra (non-metro), Tamil Nadu (non-Chennai)
Device & Data	Android smartphone; 4G data; 5–8 hrs daily screen time
Career State	Feels unprepared for placements; unsure which tech stack to learn
Prior Behaviour	Has tried ≥1 free MOOC or YouTube course; did not complete
Affordability	Family income Rs 3L–10L/year; willing to spend Rs 100–500/month on career tools
Trigger	Placement season 6–12 months away OR first campus interview failed

03 Primary Buyer Persona — 'Placement Priya'

Demographic	Detail
Age / Location	21 · Nagpur, Maharashtra
Degree	B.Tech CSE, Tier 3 college, Final Year
Family Income	Rs 4–6 LPA household
Budget	Rs 200–400/month for career tools
Device	Android mid-range smartphone
Social Channels	Instagram, YouTube, WhatsApp
Decision Speed	1–3 days
Influencers	Senior students, YouTube creators
Pain Score	9/10
WTP Score	6/10

Goal	Land a software job at Rs 4–6 LPA; build a portfolio; master DSA
Core Frustration	"I don't know where to start. Everyone says different things."
Workaround	Random YouTube binging; asking seniors; trial-and-error courses
Discovery	Instagram Reel · College WhatsApp group · Friend referral
Motivation	Financial independence; proving family's investment worthwhile
Fear	Wrong career choice → wasted 4 years; unemployment; family disappointment

04 Top 10 Customer Pain Points

#	Pain Point	Intensity	Current Workaround
1	No personalised learning roadmap — overwhelmed by choice	10/10	Random YouTube binging
2	Cannot identify skill gaps before interviews	9/10	Mock test apps (partial fix)
3	Career counsellors expensive or unavailable in Tier 2/3	9/10	Ask seniors / trial-and-error
4	No meaningful way to track learning progress	8/10	Spreadsheets or nothing
5	Don't know which companies hire from their college	8/10	LinkedIn stalking
6	Fear of wrong career choice leading to wasted time	7/10	Paralysis / delay
7	Poor resume quality leads to no shortlists	7/10	Free templates online
8	No visibility into where peers stand (benchmarking gap)	7/10	Informal senior comparison
9	Placement cells are understaffed and give generic advice	6/10	Walk-in sessions (infrequent)
10	No mock interview or company-specific prep in one place	6/10	Pramp / InterviewBit (fragmented)

05 Customer Journey Map

Stage	User Action	Emotion	SkillBoost Touchpoint	Success Metric
Awareness	Sees IG Reel / WhatsApp share / college group post	Curious, hopeful	Viral short-form content; student testimonials	CTR > 3%
Consideration	Visits landing page; reads reviews; explores features	Interested but sceptical	Clear value prop; peer reviews; free demo	Bounce < 40%
Activation	Signs up; completes onboarding quiz	Excited	Smooth onboarding; first roadmap in <60 sec	Onboarding > 70%
Engagement	Follows daily plan; completes first module	Motivated	Daily nudges; progress bar; streak system	D7 retention > 40%
Conversion	Hits free tier limit; prompted to upgrade	Invested — doesn't want to stop	Clear value demo; Rs 99 entry offer	Free→Paid > 8%

Retention	Uses platform weekly for skill tracking + mock prep	Confident, accountable	Weekly progress emails; new content drops	D30 retention > 25%
Advocacy	Shares referral link in hostel / WhatsApp group	Proud, helpful	Referral programme: 1 month free per referral	Viral coeff > 0.4

06 Key Objections & Buying Triggers

Objection	Response Strategy	Trigger	Timing	SkillBoost Response
"I can find this free on YouTube"	Position as curator + accountability	Placement season announced	7–9 months pre-grad	Personalised placement roadmap in 60 sec
"I can't afford a subscription"	7-day free trial + Rs 99 starter tier. E	Failed first campus interview	Any time Yr 3/4	Gap analysis + recovery plan
"I don't trust AI for career decisions"	Show mentor-verified roadmap temp	Friend got a placement offer	Any time	Social proof + FOMO-driven trial
"My college has a placement cell"	Position as complement. Most cells personalised.	Watched motivational coding video	Any time	Targeted IG/YouTube ad retarget
"I'll start next semester"	Create urgency: students who start	New semester begins	June & December	Semester skill-plan campaign

07 MVP Recommendation

Build First — Core Value Loop

- AI-generated personalised learning roadmap (based on current skills + career goal)
- Skill-gap assessment quiz (15–20 questions, dynamic output)
- Daily progress tracker with streak system and milestone alerts
- WhatsApp / email nudge engine for habit formation
- Simple freemium gate: full roadmap locked after 7-day trial

Do NOT Build Yet — Save for v2+

- Mock interview AI engine (high build cost; validate retention first)
- Peer benchmarking / social leaderboard (premature — needs user base)
- Vernacular / regional language support (Phase 2 after Hindi-English PMF)
- Corporate L&D; / B2B college dashboard (pivot option, not core yet)
- Resume AI builder (complementary, not differentiating at seed stage)

MVP Success Metrics

Metric	Target	Timeframe
Onboarding completion rate	> 65%	Week 2
D7 retention	> 35%	Week 2
D30 retention	> 25%	Month 1
Free → Paid conversion	> 8%	Month 1
Paying users (Month 1)	>= 30	Month 1
Referral rate	> 15%	Week 3
NPS from early cohort	> 40	Month 1

08 MoSCoW Feature Prioritisation

Priority	Features
MUST HAVE	Personalised AI roadmap generator · Skill-gap quiz · Progress tracker · Streak system · Freemium paywall · WhatsApp nudges
SHOULD HAVE	Daily email digest · Resource curation per skill · Company hiring requirements DB · Basic resume tips · Mobile-first PWA
COULD HAVE	Peer cohort comparison (anonymous) · Referral programme · College WhatsApp bot integration · Placement season countdown
WON'T HAVE (v1)	Live mentor sessions · AI mock interviewer · Vernacular UI · B2B college dashboard · Resume builder · Job board

09 Pricing Hypothesis

Tier	Price	Features	Target Segment
Free	Rs 0	7-day full access → 1 roadmap, limited tracking	Discovery & habit formation
Starter	Rs 99/month	Full roadmap + progress tracker + nudges	Price-sensitive Yr 2/3 students
Pro	Rs 299/month	Starter + skill-gap updates + company prep tips	Placement-season Yr 4 students
Pro Annual	Rs 1,999/year	Pro features at ~56% saving (Rs 166/month)	Committed learners; lower churn

Premium	Rs 499/month	Pro + mock interview prep + priority content	High-intent, higher-income segment
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- ARPU hypothesis: Rs 200/month blended = ~\$2.4/user/year at scale.
- Validate Rs 99 and Rs 299 price points with 50 paying users before fixing the ladder.
- Annual plan reduces churn and improves LTV — push from month 3 onwards.

10 Top 5 Risks & Mitigations

#	Risk	Severity	Mitigation
1	Solo founder burnout — execution bandwidth and investor confidence	CRITICAL	Find co-founder (growth/sales) or join accelerator (Antler India / Surge) within 60 days
2	Low paid conversion (<5%) — students resist paying even at Rs 99	HIGH	A/B test pricing; add high-perceived-value feature (company-specific prep); 7-day trial
3	Big EdTech (Unacademy, GUVI) copies personalisation feature	HIGH	Build community moat; move fast; double down on Tier 2/3 niche they structurally ignore
4	AI hallucination in career advice erodes trust	HIGH	Human-verified roadmap templates + clear AI disclaimer layer + expert review toggle
5	Poor D30 retention (<20%) — no habit formed	HIGH	Invest in onboarding flow; streak/gamification; daily WhatsApp nudge; weekly progress email

11 30-Day MVP Plan

Week	Focus	Key Actions	Success Metric
Week 1 Days 1–7	User Research	• Interview 20 Tier 2/3 students • Document top 5 pain points with evidence • Map current user journey • Set up PostHog analytics	20 interviews done Pain point doc complete
Week 2 Days 8–14	Product & Retention	• Rebuild onboarding to < 3 minutes • Launch streak + progress tracking • Add daily WhatsApp / email nudges • Fix top 2 D7 drop-off points	Onboarding > 65% D7 retention > 35%
Week 3 Days 15–21	Distribution & Growth	• Launch in 3 college WhatsApp groups • Partner with 2 college tech clubs • Post 5 short-form videos (IG/YouTube) • Set up referral programme	300+ new signups Referral rate > 15%
Week 4 Days 22–30	Monetisation Test	• Soft-launch Rs 99/month to 100 power users • A/B test 2 pricing pages • Apply to Antler India / Surge / YC • Begin co-founder search	>= 30 paying users Accelerator application submitted

12 Founder Action Sheet — Top 10 Next Actions

#	Action	Timing	Success Signal
1	Interview 20 students (structured, this week)	Days 1–5	Pain evidence doc
2	Rebuild onboarding to < 3 min; add streak system	Days 6–10	Onboarding > 65%
3	Set up PostHog / Mixpanel retention tracking	Day 1	Analytics live
4	Launch in 3 college WhatsApp groups (organic)	Week 2	300+ signups
5	Post 5 short-form videos on Instagram/YouTube	Week 3	CTR > 3%
6	Soft-launch Rs 99/month pricing to power users	Week 4	30 paying users
7	Begin co-founder search — AngelList, IIT/NIT networks	Week 2	3+ conversations
8	Apply to Antler India, Surge, and Y Combinator	Week 4	Applications submitted
9	Read 'The Mom Test' before next user interview	Day 1	Better interview quality

10	Register as Private Limited Company (Razorpay Rize)	Week 2	Legal entity active
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13 Scores & Final Verdict

Dimension	Score	Weight	Weighted	Assessment
Customer Clarity	82/100	20%	16.4	ICP and persona are specific and evidence-backed
Problem Severity	88/100	20%	17.6	High intensity; real pain; massive underserved segment
PMF Potential	76/100	20%	15.2	Strong signal; retention metrics must confirm hypothesis
MVP Readiness	71/100	15%	10.7	Prototype exists; onboarding & retention need polish
Competitive Moat	65/100	15%	9.8	No direct rival; window is 12–18 months before big EdTech pivots
Business Model	68/100	10%	6.8	Freemium sound; paid conversion unvalidated at scale
OVERALL	74/100	100%	74.0	Conditional GO — validate retention & paying cohort

■ FINAL VERDICT: STRONG DEMAND SIGNAL | CONDITIONAL GO Problem is real, large and underserved. Founder-market fit is exceptional. Build the retention loop first — then monetise.

This report was generated from the SkillBoost AI Startup Validation Report (June 2025). All market data sourced from publicly available EdTech industry reports. Projections are estimates based on comparable early-stage EdTech startups in India.
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